

DEBESH CHAND

PRODUCT LEADER | EX-UPGRAD • EX-OYO | IIM LUCKNOW

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SUMMARY

Product leader with 8+ years in product (10 years total), owning B2C growth portfolios across **acquisition, conversion, and retention** — with proven depth in AI-powered product thinking, experimentation, and funnel optimisation. Led a **10-member cross-functional org at upGrad across a ₹130 Cr+ quarterly portfolio**; scaled OYO Wizard to **1M+ paid members**. Prioritise step-change bets while maintaining a balance of high-velocity incremental wins.

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

3% → 12% visitor-to-lead conversion (upGrad)	₹20 Cr+/qtr revenue unlocked on flat traffic (upGrad)	₹60L+/year tooling costs saved (upGrad)	1M+ paid loyalty members (OYO)	20L+ DAU consumer platform owned (OYO)
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PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

upGrad, Director of Product (Growth & Acquisitions) - Bengaluru **Apr 2021 - Mar 2026**
Led **10-member org (PMs, designers, UX writers)** across acquisition, conversion, and assisted revenue.
Promoted from PM II → Director (**3 promotions in 5 years**)

- Architected an AI-powered decisioning layer for sales quality — automated call scoring and behavioural assessment via 100+ validated rubrics; **pitch scores up 30%, call-to-payment up 15%**, audit team **8→2**
- Created an LLM-powered behavioural scoring platform — cohort-based career risk modeling reaching professionals outside upGrad's TAM; 40K leads/month, **₹6.7 Cr incremental quarterly revenue**
- Drove visitor-to-lead conversion **3%→12%** by rebuilding acquisition funnel around user decisions — separating paid and organic experiences was the **critical unlock**; paid conversion moved **2%→9%**
- Unlocked **₹20 Cr incremental quarterly revenue** on flat traffic through funnel re-architecture — managed CXO alignment via milestone-based experimentation plan with defined checkpoints
- Identified fence-sitter conversion pattern via call analysis; built a data-driven personalisation engine matching users to relevant alumni profiles — driving **10% uplift in lead-to-payment (~₹4.5 Cr quarterly)**
- Diagnosed sampling anxiety as the activation barrier; shipped a 7-day onboarding journey with gated content and conversion nudges — delivering **32% revenue lift, ₹8.3 Cr → ₹10.9 Cr quarterly**
- Engineered a viral growth loop by replacing a manual referral process with a scalable multi-tenant engine; referral channel scaled to 15% of BU revenue (**₹45 Cr annually**) at 3× lower CAC
- Pioneered upGrad's first self-serve checkout; identified conversion blockers, aligned payments and SAP teams to automate it — enabling **5% visitor-to-payment conversion** without sales dependency
- Built org-wide A/B testing and experimentation platform from scratch — enabled rapid hypothesis testing and cohort-level iteration across all growth surfaces; eliminated **₹60L+/year** vendor dependency
- Challenged over-reliance on late-stage conversion (~21% organic ceiling); pivoted to new acquisition surfaces — unlocking **₹8 Cr incremental revenue per quarter** (10% of BU) within 2 quarters
- Overhauled siloed PM structure into journey pods (traffic → lead → payment) with clear metric ownership per pod — achieved **20% funnel conversion lift and 25% revenue per lead** within 18 months
- Built the product stack for upGrad's offline channel from zero — countered CXO scope push with footfall data, locked phase 1; reached **₹10.8 Cr quarterly at 2% lead-to-payment** across 40+ stores
- Diagnosed CAC ceiling from paid channels; led team of 8 to build a content + free-resources acquisition engine, reaching a segment invisible to paid — generating **₹6 Cr quarterly revenue at near-zero CAC**
- Engineered a self-serve affiliate platform to eliminate 10-day onboarding bottleneck — cut TAT to **5 hrs**, expanding to 30+ partners in 3 months, reaching **₹5 Cr quarterly revenue**

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE (CONTINUED)

OYO, Product Manager - Gurgaon

Apr 2018 - Mar 2021

Owned consumer booking journey, Wizard loyalty program & UK market expansion; promoted **PM I → PM II**

- Broke down and rebuilt OYO's booking discovery funnel across **20L+ DAU platform** — use-case storefronts, map-based discovery, intent-driven filters; lifting booking conversion **8%→16%**
- Tapped deal-seeking as OYO's core conversion behaviour; redesigned discovery with personalised offer zone and weekly time-gated mystery deals — yielding **3% net booking revenue uplift**
- Solved zero-switching-cost churn by launching OYO Wizard — ₹99 membership with **5% recurring booking discount**; scaled to **1M+ paid members annually**, improving member **LTV by 2.2x**
- Deepened Wizard monetisation with 2 premium tiers (₹299) and a member referral programme — delivered **20% premium-tier sales penetration** and **7% referral contribution** to membership revenue
- Uncovered UK market fit gap; built hotel owner trust as new entrant through 40+ sessions and transparent scoping — resolved pilot churn, onboarded **2,000+ rooms in 6 months**, **NPS doubled 4→8**

Amdocs, Software Developer - Pune

Jul 2014 - May 2016

Developed large-scale telecom systems supporting customer lifecycle workflows for a global operator

- Re-architected plan-change & provisioning flows for a global telecom operator — **~17% adoption uplift** and **~15% faster network activation**
- Led quality system redesign across 40+ engineers, **reducing defect density by ~35%**

SKILLS

Growth & Experimentation - Growth Strategy, Funnel Optimization, A/B Testing & Experimentation, Conversion Rate Optimization (CRO), Experiment Design, Monetization Design, Referral & Loyalty Mechanics · 0→1 Product Development

Analytics & Data - GA4, Tableau, Clevertap, SQL (working knowledge), Data Analysis, Cohort Analysis, Funnel Analytics, Attribution Modeling, User Research & Discovery

AI & Platforms - AI Product Thinking, AI-enabled Revenue Systems, Lead Scoring Models, CRM Automation, Marketing Automation, Multi-tenant CMS Architecture, Experimentation Platform (in-house build) · S2S Integrations

Leadership & Execution

Cross-functional Leadership · Executive Stakeholder Management · Product Strategy · Team Building (PMs, Designers)

EDUCATION

P.G.D.M. (M.B.A.), IIM Lucknow

Jun 2016 - Mar 2018

Major in Marketing and Strategy | 7.06/10

B.E., Jabalpur Engineering College

Aug 2010 - May 2014

Electronics and Communication | 76.5% (Hons.)